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Gen Z adults and younger millennials are “completely overwhelmed” by stress

20- and 30-somethings in the United States are burdened by financial woes and isolation, APA's 2023 Stress in America report finds

By [Anna Medaris](#) Date created: November 1, 2023 5 min read

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When “Hannah” graduated from college in 2019, her future looked bright: She’d landed an internship in media, moved to New York City, and joined a theater troupe where she quickly found community.

But just months later, the COVID-19 pandemic hit. Then in early 2023, her relationship ended, she got laid off, and anxiety set in. Now 26 and back in school for social work, Hannah doesn’t feel “young and carefree.”

“Not knowing what your future is going to look like in a world where nobody knows what the collective future is going to look like is, to say the least, overwhelming,” said Hannah, whose name has been changed to protect her future job prospects.

Young adults in America like Hannah are reporting higher stress levels than older generations, with 18- to 34-year-olds saying their average stress level is a 6 out of 10, compared with a 3.4 among people ages 65 and older, APA’s 2023 Stress in America survey ([/news/press/releases/stress/2023/collective-trauma-recovery](https://www.apa.org/news/press/releases/stress/2023/collective-trauma-recovery)) found. Last year, this younger cohort said their average stress was a 5.8.

“Some stressors are fairly common during this life transition—career decisions, finances, planning for the future—but I

believe something is different about what 20- to 30-year-olds are dealing with right now,” said Chelsea Dudley, PsyD, a clinical psychologist at [Coastal Therapy Group](https://coastaltherapygroup.com/) (https://coastaltherapygroup.com/) in Carlsbad, California, where she specializes in working with teens and young adults. She cited inflation, spotty health care access, and the aftermath of COVID as compounding factors.

Indeed, research shows that [older adults tend to handle stress better](https://doi.org/10.1037/0882-7974.20.2.330) (https://doi.org/10.1037/0882-7974.20.2.330) than younger people, especially if they’re able to give back in some way, said [Cecilia Poon, PhD, ABPP](https://www.nebraskamed.com/doctors/cecilia-yee-man-poon) (https://www.nebraskamed.com/doctors/cecilia-yee-man-poon), internship training director in Nebraska Medicine’s psychology department and a board-certified geropsychologist.

That’s not to say older generations are stress-free, or that the 65-and-up crew is a monolith, she added. “People in their 60s who are from the baby boom generation are not exactly dealing with the same stress as those in earlier-born generations,” Poon said. And older adults from different racial and ethnic backgrounds, those in rural America, and those who identify as LGBTQA+ all face varying types and intensities of stressors.

“What are their experiences as they juggle their identities, health care needs, and their children moving away?” said Poon, who also serves on APA’s Division 20 (Adult Development and Aging) executive committee. “And what about older adults with war trauma? They are re-experiencing a lot right now with all of the local and international conflicts.”

Financial worries weigh heavily

From issues like discrimination and human rights to personal safety and violence, it’s all stressful to younger Americans. But, like their older counterparts, health- and finance-related concerns topped the list of stressors.

Specifically, the survey found 18–34 and 35–44-year-olds were more likely than those 65 and older to report they feel “consumed” by their worries about money (67% and 63% vs. 13%, respectively).

“I’ve noticed more financial stress among my younger clients compared to a year ago, and I think that is completely understandable given this research and where our practice is located—in a high cost-of-living area,” Dudley said.

Younger peoples' financial stress doesn't occur in a vacuum, Poon pointed out. In fact, when it means their elders are shouldering their costs or taking them back in, it can trickle up to older generations, too.

“There has been so much stress on older parents and grandparents, especially when their children or grandchildren are legally involved or unhoused,” said Poon. “This is on top of existing caregiving demands of spouses, and, increasingly, children who are aging with or into disability.”

But younger people report the deepest consequences of stress. In the survey, about two-thirds of 18- to 34-year-olds said stress makes it hard for them to focus (67%) and feel as though no one understands how stressed they are (66%). That age group was also most likely to say that most days, their stress is “completely overwhelming” (58%), that it renders them numb (50%), and that most days they are so stressed they can't function.

And younger cohorts are less inclined to report that they can recover from stress quickly.

“We are talking about an age group where 18- and 19-year-olds had to finish high school online and start college or their

careers during so much uncertainty. No wonder they feel that people don't understand what that kind of stress is like,” Dudley said. “For individuals on the upper end of this age group, they had to learn how to manage starting families and helping their young children through the pandemic, while also functioning themselves.”

Indeed, the survey found parents of those under 18 also bore the weight of stress, with about half (49%) saying they feel completely stressed out no matter what they do, 64% saying they wish they had someone to help them manage their stress, and 62% saying no one understands how stressed out they are.

Increasing isolation isn't helping

While strong social connections are a [well-documented defense against stress \(/topics/stress/manage-social-support\)](#), young people seem to struggle most to make them.

APA's survey found that 74% of those ages 18 to 34 and 70% of those ages 35 to 44 say it's harder to connect with people today than in the past, and 70% of 18-34-year-olds and 65% of

35-44-year-olds say they wish someone would check in with them more frequently.

But the report wasn't all discouraging. Younger adults were most likely to feel confident about the direction of the country, and to say they believed elected officials had their best interests in mind.

As one 41-year-old man said: “The future to me looks bright and full of possibilities. I look forward to how life is going to surprise me, both in the good and the bad, and to the journey of becoming my best self.”

For younger people lacking such optimism, Dudley suggested turning to proven stress management tactics (</topics/stress/manage-stress-tools>), such as calling a friend or deep breathing. “Look for what is meaningful in your life that you want to invest more time in, and start small,” she said. “Little by little, the small steps will turn into meaningful change.”

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